

The Swiss Style.

A reference document demonstrating typography, grid,
and palette discipline of the md4x Swiss-style template.

A reference document demonstrating the Swiss-style template — typography, layout, and color discipline. The body text should remain readable across long sections without fatigue.

1.1 Origins

Swiss style — also known as the International Typographic Style — emerged in Switzerland during the 1950s. It values legibility, objectivity, and rationalism. Type is sans-serif. Layouts use a mathematical grid. Color is restrained, often black with a single accent.

The style is most associated with designers like Josef Müller-Brockmann, Armin Hofmann, and Emil Ruder. Their work shaped corporate identity, signage, editorial design, and typography for decades.

1.2 Principles

The style follows a small set of recurring rules:

- **Sans-serif typography** — usually Helvetica, Akzidenz-Grotesk, or Univers.
- **Asymmetric layouts** anchored to a strict grid.
- **Ragged-right text** — never justified.
- **Generous whitespace** treated as a structural element, not decoration.
- **Restrained palette** — black, sometimes a single accent (often red).

TYPOGRAPHY

Helvetica became the canonical face. It is neutral, geometric, and demands the discipline of the surrounding layout to give it expression. Hierarchy is built from weight and size, not from changing typefaces.

COLOR

A small number of high-contrast colors. Black is the default. A single accent — typically a saturated red — marks emphasis. Backgrounds stay white.

1.3 Composition

A 12-column grid is common. Modular columns hold text, images, and captions in measured relation. Whitespace is structural, not decorative.

ELEMENT	TREATMENT
Body	Helvetica, 10 pt, 14.5 leading
H1	Helvetica Bold, 22 pt, flush left
H2	Helvetica Bold, 13 pt, numbered
Caption	Helvetica, 8 pt, set in red
Code	JetBrains Mono, 9 pt, gray ground

1.4 Code and figures

Code blocks adopt the same restrained palette — light gray background, no rounded corners, monospace.

```
fn main() {  
    let style = "swiss";  
    println!("md4x - {} template", style);  
}
```

A blockquote, set with a thin red rule on the left and otherwise no ornamentation. The grid is what does the work.

1.5 A short ordered list

1. Establish a grid before placing any text.
2. Pick one type family. Use weight, not faces, for hierarchy.
3. Reserve color for one or two roles. Stick to them.
4. Use whitespace as if it were ink.

1.6 Conclusion

The Swiss style is a discipline more than a vocabulary. Its components are few; its constraints are firm; its results are unmistakable.